

MIG-8

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-8

Age: 30

Gender: Male

Country of origin: Somalia

Host country: United Kingdom

Years in host country: 5

Occupation: Community Worker

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I arrived in the United Kingdom five years ago as a refugee, fleeing the ongoing conflict and chronic instability that have plagued Somalia for so long. My family had already been displaced multiple times within the region before I made the decision to seek safety further afield, moving from place to place in search of somewhere the violence could not reach us. The UK offered the promise of genuine safety and, crucially, a chance at education and a future, so I claimed asylum here after a long, exhausting, and often perilous journey across several countries, never certain of what awaited me at the end of it. Rebuilding from that starting point, with nothing but what I carried and what I remembered, has been the defining struggle of my adult life.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means being valued as a British citizen who happens also to be Somali, rather than being perpetually questioned about whether I truly belong here, as though my presence required ongoing justification. It shows itself when my community's contributions are genuinely recognised and celebrated, and when young Somalis growing up here can see themselves reflected in the institutions of the society around them, in positions of respect and influence. Real inclusion, as I understand it through my work, is having a genuine stake in the country and a real voice in shaping its future, being a full participant in the national life rather than a tolerated presence on its margins, always slightly apart.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: Xenophobia is a regular and wearing feature of life here, and in my case it is compounded by the fact that I am simultaneously Black, Muslim, and a refugee, so that different forms of prejudice overlap and reinforce one another. I have faced open hostility on public transport, hostile stares and muttered comments, and I have watched the rise of anti-immigrant rhetoric in the public conversation with real concern. After certain political events and campaigns, the atmosphere grew noticeably and measurably more hostile toward visible minorities like myself and my community, as though permission had been granted for people to express feelings they had previously kept quiet. It affects how safe and welcome one feels moving through ordinary public space.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The biggest challenges were the deep trauma of displacement, of losing home and stability and certainty, combined with the complex and drawn-out asylum process, which left me in a distressing state of limbo for a long time, unable to plan or to fully begin my new life. Adjusting to a completely different climate, culture, and set of social expectations was genuinely hard, disorienting in ways large and small. Finding stable housing and employment as a refugee, while frequently facing discrimination from landlords and employers who saw only my background, tested my resilience to its limits during those early years, and there were many moments when the weight of it all felt almost unbearable.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: I now work in community organising and support, an environment that is diverse, mission-driven, and animated by a shared commitment to helping people, and I feel genuinely supported and valued within it. My colleagues understand the challenges that migrants and refugees face, often from personal experience, so I do not have to explain or justify myself constantly the way I might in other settings. This work gives me a profound sense of purpose, allowing me to help other newcomers navigate the very systems and obstacles that I once found so bewildering and isolating when I first arrived here, alone and uncertain. Turning my own hard experience into something useful for others has been deeply healing.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I proudly maintain my Somali identity through my language, through my Islamic faith which anchors me, and through strong and active ties to the Somali community here in Britain. I mentor Somali young people specifically to help them stay connected to their heritage, their history, and their language, so that it is not lost. Simultaneously, I have genuinely embraced British civic values, the rule of law, democratic participation, a certain tolerance, and I feel a real and growing loyalty to this country that took me in. I am unapologetically both Somali and British at once, and I see absolutely no contradiction between the two; each enriches the other in my life.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: British media frequently frames refugees and Muslims in negative terms, associating us with terrorism, with crime, or with being a drain on public resources and services, rarely acknowledging what we contribute. This kind of coverage directly fuels xenophobia and makes our everyday lives materially harder, shaping how strangers regard us before any word is exchanged. In my community work I try actively to counter these damaging narratives by highlighting the very real positive contributions of the Somali community across the UK, the businesses, the professionals, the volunteers, the young people succeeding against the odds. The negative story is amplified endlessly, while the ordinary reality of hardworking, law-abiding families is almost entirely absent from the coverage.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: The support available for refugees varies enormously by region and has, in my time here, been cut back significantly under successive budgets, leaving real gaps in provision. Charities and voluntary organisations have stepped in to fill many of the spaces that the government has vacated, offering crucial help with housing, legal aid, and orientation that would otherwise simply not exist. My own

experience of that inadequate and patchy official support is precisely what motivated me to work in this sector in the first place, because I saw with my own eyes how much people were left to struggle and how much difference even a little well-directed help could make. The system relies far too heavily on the goodwill of underfunded charities.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: I work closely with the second generation of Somali-British young people, and I see them caught, often painfully, between cultures, sometimes facing a genuine identity crisis that is compounded by the racism they encounter and by limited economic opportunities in the areas where many of them grow up. Some of them struggle badly with this pressure, and I do what I can to support them through it. But many others are extraordinarily ambitious, articulate, and proud of who they are, and they are actively redefining what it means to be British on their own terms, refusing the false choice between their heritage and their country. Watching them come into their own is one of the great rewards of my work.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, we need honest and serious education about Britain's colonial history and about the real reasons that people are compelled to migrate, because so much hostility rests on ignorance of both. Political leaders must stop scapegoating migrants for systemic failures, in housing, in public services, that have quite different causes, because that cynical blame-shifting poisons community relations. And grassroots contact between communities is genuinely powerful; in my direct experience, when people from different backgrounds work together on shared local issues that concern them all, the artificial divisions between 'us' and 'them' begin to break down and are gradually replaced by relationships built on common purpose.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to expand my community work into a larger and more sustainable organisation that can empower refugees and newcomers across the UK more effectively than we currently manage with limited means. I want to see more Somalis moving into positions of genuine influence, from local and national politics to business and the professions, so that our community is represented where decisions are made. And on a personal level, I dream of a stable and peaceful Somalia, one that my future children could safely visit and come to know as a living part of their heritage, rather than only as a place of conflict and departure that exists in stories.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to newcomers is to seek out community organisations early on, because they are a vital lifeline in every sense and can connect you to help you would never find alone. Learn your legal rights and how the system actually works, thoroughly and as soon as you can, because knowledge protects you from exploitation and mistakes. Invest seriously in education, because it genuinely transforms your prospects and opens doors that would otherwise remain closed. Build bridges with other communities rather than isolating yourself within your own, however comforting that isolation might feel. And, wherever you can, channel your own struggles into helping those who come after you, because there is real strength and healing in that.